MASTER OF BUSINESS ADMINISTRATION

SEMESTER 1



DMBA114

BUSINESS COMMUNICATION

Unit – 5

Internal and External Business Communication – Writing Business Reports

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1. INTRODUCTION

Having discussed different forms of internal and external business communicaton, another important form of business communication is business reports. These are also communication methods employed to communicate with both internal and external stakeholders of an organisation. In this unit, we will learn the format of a business report.

Report on Employee Evaluation

For Donald Williams, this particular process has been uncharacteristically difficult. He knows that a decision must be made. Despite the many hours and tireless analysis put forth, a sound decision seems unobtainable. Williams is the Human Resource (HR) Director for Direct Supply. For the past couple of days, he has been reviewing the conduct and work production of one of Direct Supply's recently hired employees. The employee, Thomas Crawford, has completed his third month of employment with Direct Supply, ending the mandatory ninety-day evaluation period for all new employees. At the completion of this period, a performance evaluation meeting is scheduled. At Direct Supply, the process of evaluating employee performance is the responsibility of the Human Resource Director and the supervisor of the employee being reviewed. The Human Resource Director reviews the employee's files and discusses the files with the employee's supervisor.

The supervising manager is required to submit a progress and summary report of a subordinate worker before a scheduled evaluation meeting takes place. In the case of Crawford, as for any other employees working in the sales division, the report consisted mostly of sales statistics, expense reports and call sheets. The information obtained from this report will be used to make evaluations of both the overall volume of productive work credited to an employee and the progress made by the employee during the initial probationary period.

In addition to the summary and progress report submitted by an employee's supervisor, the HR Director may also request other bits of information from various departments within the company. One such report that is produced by the IT department is referred to as a technology report. Included in this report is information about an employee's access to the company's electronic services and information. Information about system login times, session durations and file access are maintained for each employee by the company's system software.

For Crawford, the progress and summary report filed by Barker was outstanding. Much of the report focused on Patterson Foods, which is currently one of Direct Supply's largest accounts.

Despite conducting much of his business outside the office, Crawford does spend a portion of each day working in the office. Tasks such as producing sales and expense reports are produced using customized software.

(Source: http://www.cerias.purdue.edu/education/post_secondary_education/past_offerings/curriculum_development/ethical_social_prof_issues/case_study_ramaswamy3.php)

The following questions arise after reading the scenario:

1. What is a report?
2. What are the types of reports?

In this unit, we will define what a business report is and its types. We will also study the format of a business report and the steps that you need to follow to create an effective report.

1.1. Objectives



After studying this unit, you should be able to:

- Define business report
- Identify the different types of business reports
- Explain the format of a business report
- List the steps for creating an effective report

2. REPORT

A business report may be defined as "an orderly and objective presentation of information that helps in decision-making and problem-solving."1 It may be in oral or written form.

The keywords in the above definition are 'orderly', 'objective', 'information', 'decision making', and problem-solving'. 'Orderly' means that a report flows in a logical sequence, for example, from a definition of the problem to analysis and recommendation of solutions. 'Objective' means that a report is written by avoiding the use of the first person, so as to avoid bias. The passive voice is used rather than the active voice, so as to give less importance to the doer of the action.

For example, "A survey was conducted with a sample size of 100 respondents" is passive voice, and "I conducted a survey among a sample size of 100 respondents" is active voice.

A report presents 'information' or 'authentic facts and data. Subjective judgments and recommendations must be based on data.

Finally, a business report, unlike a scientific or academic report, must aid 'decision-making' and 'problem-solving'. For example, a report on the market feasibility of a new product must help management to decide whether to launch the new product or not.

A business report has certain unique characteristics, they are:

A report varies in purpose, length, format and complexity

The purpose of a business report may be to inform, analyse or persuade. A report that seeks to merely inform the reader is a simple report and it states facts with no persuasive intent. An example of a report with this purpose is a report on company policies and procedures. Other examples are sales reports, monthly departmental reports, and project reports showing progress on projects.

Sometimes a report may have the twin purpose of informing as well as analysing. Merely providing data may be meaningless, unless the data is analysed and interpreted. All research reports like market research reports based on surveys, come under this category. The information gathered from a survey is analysed and then presented in a meaningful form.

A business report may also have the purpose of persuading or recommending a course of action. A research report may also make some suggestions, based on the data and the analysis of the data. A marketing strategy report submitted to top management and proposals to the government seeking

funds for building a research facility or for some other purposes are other examples of persuasive reports.

Business reports vary from simple one-page memo formats to more complex reports such as 'manuscript reports', running to several pages. Research reports are the most complex and the longest of all reports. The purpose of the report determines the length, format, and complexity. The different formats will be discussed in detail in ensuing sections.

Report quality is affected by the quality and accuracy of the data - A report may be perfectly written, but may still be of poor quality, if the data collected is not accurate or if the process of data collection itself is faulty. For example, a research report may be well written and presented, but the sample selected for the survey may be too small or not representative enough of the population.

Regarding the accuracy of data, take the example of a report recommending the purchase of an overhead projector (OHP) for the company's conference room. Suppose you have been asked to study the features of different brands of OHPs and come up with a recommendation. If you recommend a brand of OHP based on its bulb life of 100 hours instead of 300 hours by mistake, your recommendation itself may be incorrect.

Thus, reports serve as a vital source of information for analysis and decision-making. Hence, it must be accurate and clear.

3. TYPES OF BUSINESS REPORTS ADVERTISING

Reports can be classified based on several criteria, including their use (progress and financial reports), purpose (informational, analytical, and persuasive reports), frequency of preparation (annual, monthly, weekly, and hourly reports), length (short and long reports) and whether they are internal to the business or are used outside the business.

The most common types of business reports may be divided into the following categories:

- **Periodic reports –** These are reports that are prepared on a regular basis, for both internal and external audiences. Their purpose is solely to inform. Examples of this type of report are:
  - **Routine management reports –** These are reports such as equipment reports and sales updates. These reports are prepared for internal audiences such as top management and shareholders.
  - **Compliance reports –** These are submitted to external stakeholders, such as the government, stating compliance with regulations such as environmental norms.
  - **Progress reports –** These reports may be prepared for both internal audiences as well as for external audiences such as customers. A project report stating progress on a long-term project is an example of this type of report.
- **Proposals** – Unlike periodic reports, the purpose of a proposal is to persuade. Proposals may be prepared for both internal and external audiences. Examples of proposals include research proposals and marketing strategy proposals to top management, proposals to the government to grant funds for building a research facility, and proposals to consumers to buy a company's products.
- **Policies and procedures** – The purpose of these reports is solely to inform. They are also prepared only for internal audiences. Examples include reports on company policies and procedures, written by top management and sent to all employees. This is part of downward communication.
- **Situational reports** – These are one-time, exceptional reports that are prepared when a unique event occurs. For example, if sales of the company have shown a significant decline, a study may be carried out to determine the reasons for declining sales, and a report prepared on the findings. Similarly, a market feasibility study may be carried out before the launch of a new product and a report prepared, based on the study. The purpose of such reports is usually to inform, analyse and persuade.

You can choose the type of report based on your requirement; therefore, it is very important to analyse and understand the requirement before you choose the report type.

SELF-ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS – 1

True or False:	
1	A business report may also have the purpose of persuading or recommending a course of action. (True/False)
Fill in the blanks:	
2	A report may be perfectly written, but may still be of poor quality if the _____is not accurate.
3	The purpose of _____and _____ reports are solely to inform.
Choose the correct Answer:	
4	Identify the type of report that was submitted to the government stating that the company is following the environmental regulations. (Pick the right option) a) Compliance reports b) Routine management reports c) Situational reports d) Policies and procedures

4. FORMAT FOR BUSINESS REPORTS

The format for a business report will depend on the length of the report. Length also determines the degree of language formality.

The simplest format for a report is the memo format, which is a one-page report. For example, calling attention to a meeting or a problem may require only one page or less and could be written in a memo format. Such reports will also be more informal than longer reports. (Refer to Unit 4 for more details on memos).

As the complexity of the problem increases, additional pages are required. The writer of the report based on the length of the report decides the format of the report with some extra parts such as Title Page, Table of Content, Appendix, etc. For example, a title page may be added to the report to impress the reader or a letter addressed to the reader may be included to indicate that the report is complete and is being sent. This is known as a 'letter of transmittal'.

Therefore, as the size of the report increases, a number of extra parts can be added, in order to assist the reader in understanding the report. The report will then be taken in a different format.

Consider the two-page persuasive proposal as shown in table 5.1, written in a 'manuscript' format, which includes a caption, subheads, and a summary, to help the reader in understanding the report clearly. A one-page memo report does not require any of these items.

Table 5.1: Proposal in Manuscript Format

SAMPLE PROPOSAL
THE BUSINESS WRITER'S HOTLINE **A Proposal submitted by Prof. Steve Martin** **Silicon Valley College of Bangalore, Karnataka, to the Fulbright Foundation** **April 3, 2008** All business writers have queries about writing style from time to time. The Business Communication faculty at Silicon Valley College of Bangalore often receives calls from business writers, asking questions about the tone, writing style and format of business letters and reports. Although a couple of business writers' hotlines exist nationwide, none is available in the city of Bangalore. Thus, the Business Communication Faculty of Silicon Valley College requests that a grant for Rs. 1.5 lakhs be awarded, for the purpose of setting up and operating a Business Writer's Hotline for

one year. This will benefit business executives in Bangalore city and the students, faculty and staff of Silicon Valley College.

Benefits of the Project

The project will fund the establishment and functioning of a Business Writer's Hotline, in which senior professors of Business Communication of Silicon Valley College will answer telephone queries on the subject of grammar, writing style and format. This service will be offered at no cost to users and will be available five days a week, from Monday to Friday. This hotline will:

- Enhance business productivity by reducing errors in writing that can cause communication problems, unnecessary delays or even wrong decisions.
- Provide a useful service to business writers, including business executives, college students and faculty, who presently have no other way of clarifying their doubts and questions.
- Project a favorable image of the college, as an asset to the business community in Bangalore.

Procedures

A Business Communication faculty member will be available to answer any telephone enquiries, during working days, between 9 am and 6 pm. Any calls received outside regular working hours will be recorded on an answering machine and a telephone response provided, before the end of the next working day.

A dedicated phone line will be installed for this purpose and incoming calls will be forwarded to the faculty members, so that they can work on other matters simultaneously.

Faculty members will only provide consultancy services and try to answer any reasonable questions related to grammar, punctuation, spelling, format, etc. They will not undertake any written work, edit anyone's writing or answer any questions that require in-depth research. Two books will serve as the standard references – The Oxford English Dictionary and The Economist Style Guide.

The hotline will begin operating on the first day of the academic calendar year, after the grant has been awarded and will continue for one year. A small advertisement announcing this service will appear in leading local dailies, such as the Times of India and The Deccan Herald.

The extent to which the service is used and the types of questions asked will be recorded. These records will show whether the needs of business writers are being met by this service and whether further training must be given to business executives.

Budget

The budget recommended for the Business Writer's Hotline for the first year of operation is as follows:

Purchase of five copies each of the two suggested reference books	Rs.	5000
Purchase of one telephone answering machine	Rs.	2000
Rental of one telephone line (12 months @ Rs. 1000 pm)	Rs.	12000
Long distance charges (12 months - estimated at Rs. 2000 pm).	Rs.	24000
Advertisements (12 months)	Rs.	100000
Miscellaneous	Rs.	7000
Total	**Rs.**	**150000**

Note: The faculty members will not be charged for their time.

Faculty Qualifications

All the faculty members of Silicon Valley College have doctoral degrees in their field and an average of ten years' teaching experience in Business Communication and related areas. Therefore, they are well equipped to answer the questions that are likely to come up.

Summary

The setting up of a Business Writer's Hotline will improve the communication skills and writing quality of business executives in Bangalore. The costs indicated above are small, compared to the benefits that will be derived from the service by business executives, students, faculty of the college and the college itself.

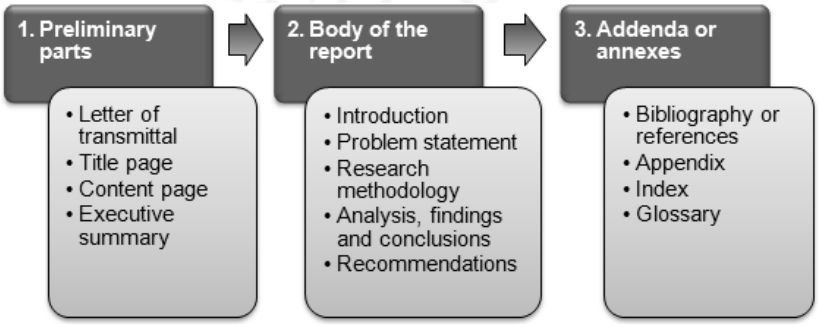


Fig. 1: Assisting Items and Sub-items of a Report

Let us now discuss the assisting items in detail.

1. **Preliminary parts** – It comprises the letter of transmittal, title page, content page and executive summary.
   a) **Letter of transmittal** – This is a letter attached to the report when it is sent to readers. It serves as a greeting and as an introduction to the report.

      For example, in a research report, the letter of transmittal shown in table 5.2 is addressed to the person in an organisation who has to authorise the study. The first sentence presents the report and reminds the reader that it was requested. It makes a brief mention of the methodology used in the study, the main findings, and the recommendations.

Table 5.2: Sample Letter of Transmittal

Dear Mr. Johnson, Here is the report of the study you requested, on the feasibility of opening a branch office in the city of Bangalore. A study of the social and economic factors of the community, an analysis of savings patterns and of the potential competition, indicates that an additional savings and loan branch office could be accommodated in Bangalore. I hope this report will assist you in making a decision. Please let me know, if you wish to discuss the report any way. Sincerely, Donald McDonald Research Associate

   b) **Title page** – As the title page creates the first impression on the reader, it must be visually appealing. The title must be clear and descriptive.

      This page must also mention the person who requested or authorised the report, the person who prepared the report, and the date on which the report was submitted.

      For example, table 5.3 depicts a sample title page of a report. The first row indicates the parts of the title page. The second row is the actual title page.

Table 5.3: Sample Report Title Page

Title	**"THE FEASIBILITY OF OPENING A BRANCH SAVINGS AND LOAN OFFICE IN BANGALORE"**
Person who requested	Prepared for: Mr. William JohnsonChairman Western Savings and Loan Association Mumbai
Person who prepared	Prepared by: Donald McDonald Research Associate Indian Market Research Organization Bangalore
Date of submission	April 1st, 2008

c) **Table of Contents (TOC) page** – The purpose of having a TOC or contents page is to help the reader locate information when a report is several pages long. It indicates how the report is organised by listing the headings of topics and subtopics along with the respective page numbers. If the report contains several graphs, tables, or figures, they must be listed separately on a separate page, under a heading such as "List of Tables and Figures". The contents page must be prepared from the outline, after writing the report.

d) **Executive summary or synopsis** – This is included in long reports to let the reader know what the report is all about, without having to read the entire report. The summary is a condensed form or an overview of the contents of the report. In a research report, the executive summary must include the purpose of the study, a brief statement of the problem, the research methodology, the main findings, conclusions, and recommendations. The executive summary may be one to two pages in length.

2. **Body of the report** – This is the main text and is the heart of the report. It must include sections such as:

a) **Introduction** – This includes the background and purpose of the study.

b) **Problem statement** – A clear definition of the problem or fundamental issue that needs to be resolved is needed.

c) **Research methodology** – A detailed explanation of the type of research that needs to be carried out, methods used for data collection, sample size, procedure and questionnaire design must be included in this section.

d) **Analysis, findings and conclusions** – The data collected must be analysed, later the findings must be presented and interpreted in a meaningful manner. Inferences must be made based on the findings. The findings could be presented in tabular or graphical form.

e) **Recommendations** – A report whose purpose is to persuade must include suggested courses of action or solutions to the defined problem, based on the findings.

3. **Addenda or annexes** – A report may also include a variety of items after the body of the report. Some of the main items in this section include:

a) **Bibliography or references** – This is a listing of all sources of information – books, journals, research papers and websites that were referred to for preparing the report. The purpose of including this section is to present documented evidence from people who are considered authorities in their field, in support of our own statements. It gives due credit to authors who were consulted, in the absence of which the author of the report can be accused of plagiarism or copying. Including a bibliography also reveals the depth of the study.

The references can be cited in the following format:

For book references:

Ellis, M., & Johnson, C. (1994). "Teaching Business English", Oxford: Oxford University Press.

For websites or webpage:

http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Wikipedia - Retrieved on February 7th 2012.

b) **Appendix** – This is a section that includes material relevant to the study but is too technical or complicated to be included in the body of the report. This is because it would hinder the reader's ability to grasp the message. Therefore, it is given in the addenda. For example, cover letters for questionnaires, the questionnaires themselves, maps, summaries of raw data, computerised models and mathematical or statistical formulas. Each item in the appendix section must be categorised and labeled as Appendix A, Appendix B, etc., and a suitable title must be given for each appendix category.

c) **Index** – This is incorporated in order to help the reader easily locate any topic or concept that is mentioned in the report. It is a list of terms or keywords mentioned in the report, used

especially as an aid in searching for information. It is generally not a part of most business reports, although it is used in some proposals, prospectuses, and annual reports. It includes a list of key terms in alphabetical order, followed by all the page numbers on which the key terms are used.

d) Glossary – This is an explanation of technical terms or jargon used in the body of the report. This section is needed only when the report is of a highly technical nature and the reader is a layperson, who is not familiar with the technical terms used. If the reader is an expert in that particular field, the glossary may be omitted. It may also be omitted if the number of such terms is small, in which case, they may be explained in the form of 'footnotes.' Where, a footnote is a note placed at the bottom of a page of a book or manuscript that comments on or cites a reference for a designated part of the text.

Business reports need not necessarily include all the items listed above. In fact, it would be rare to find all these items in a single report. They have been mentioned only to illustrate all the possible parts that a business report could include. For example, the preliminary parts and the addenda items only support the body of the report. The purpose, type, length and formality of the report would determine which of the items to include.

Table 5.4 shows the sample report.

Table 5.4: Sample Report

On the choice of a suitable site for a branch factory in Madhya Pradesh

To

The Directors, Pawan Glass Works,

New Delhi.

Terms of Reference

The sub-committee was appointed by Resolution No. 345 adopted at a meeting of the board of Directors, held on 10th January, 2006. The sub- committee, consisting of Mr. Ravi Prakash, convener, Mr. Rajiv Mehta and Mr. Vijay Singhania, were authorised to choose a suitable site for a branch factory for producing glassware in Madhya Pradesh.

Procedure

The sub-committee held three meetings on 13th, 29th January and 28th February.

The members also met the Government and Municipal authorities to enquire about permission, licenses, and water and power connections.

Findings

The sub-committee felt that Indore is the most suitable city for a glasswork factory. The choice seems to be appropriate owing to the local market as well as export facilities.

Other conditions are:

- **Raw materials:** All the components for the manufacture of glass are available in Indore glass factories. Specialized agents regularly supply fine sand from the banks of the Narmada Rivers.
- **Staff and workers:** Supervisory staff and skilled and unskilled labourers are available. It is a big trade center. Dewas and Pithampur are the areas where lots of industries are available. The salaries and wages are higher than in the other cities but the quality of work is of a high standard. Highly qualified technicians and designers receive very high salaries in Indore but the market will compensate for the expense of such staff. If the existing staff leave, replacement is possible quick time.

  Power and water: The Government authorities have agreed to give electricity and water connections to supply the required quantities of power and water. They agreed to give the connections within a fortnight.
- **Site:** There are three suitable sites of 3, 5 and 6 acres at Rajvada, Sanwere and Mahu respectively. All are available for a nine-year lease period.

Recommendations

The sub-committee recommends that:

- One of the sites has been chosen in consultation with the Company's Architects. Technically, the site at Mahu is the best.
- Negotiations be started immediately to acquire the selected site. For that, the services of brokers are to be taken.
- The Secretary is authorized to send tenders for the construction of the factory.
- The Secretary is further authorized to apply to the Government of India for license to import the required machines.
- Manpower availability data from employment exchange is to be obtained.

Date: 5th March, 2006. Mr. Ravi Prakash Mr. Vijay Singhania

Place: New Delhi.

Mr. Rajiv Mehta

(Source: Sehgal, M.K., & Khetarpal, V. (2011). Business Communication. New Delhi: Excel Books)

Activity - 1

Imagine that you are the Librarian of a college and that you have been asked by the Principal to submit a proposal for reorganisation of the library. Write a report with your recommendations for making better use of the space available and for computerising the facilities.
(Refer section 4 for detailed guidelines.)

SELF-ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS – 2

True or False:	
5	As the size of the report increases, a number of extra parts can be removed, in order to assist the reader in understanding the report. (True/False)
6	Index is a list of terms or keywords mentioned in the report, used especially as an aid in searching for information. (True/False)
Choose the correct answer:	
7	Which of the following sub-items belongs to the body of the report? (Pick the right option) a) Executive summary b) Recommendations c) Glossary d) Content page
Fill in the Blanks:	
8	_____includes the background and purpose of the study.
9	The glossary section is needed only when the report is of a high _____nature and the reader are a _____.

5. STEPS IN REPORT PREPARATION

Reports are key to the success of any business, as they are used to communicate information to top management, customers, shareholders, etc., for decision-making or persuasion. Therefore, they must be carefully planned, organised, written, and presented. A lot of groundwork must precede the actual writing of the report. We shall briefly discuss the five main steps in report preparation.

Figure 2 depicts the steps for preparing a report.



Fig. 2: Report Preparation Steps

Let us now discuss the steps shown in figure 2 briefly.

1. **Planning the report** – The first question to be asked before gathering information and writing the report concerns the type of report that is required. (Refer to section 3 for types of the report). Secondly, you must remember that most reports are required by the management to solve a problem or to make a decision. Therefore, the basis or starting point for a report is a problem. Reports are written after a problem is analysed and a solution to the problem is found. The problem may be of a day-to-day nature, such as determining which brand of an overhead projector to recommend for purchase, or the problem may be a negative one, such as sales of the company showing a decline. In any case, the problem is the fundamental issue to be addressed in the report and must be clearly determined, right at the beginning.

Once the problem has been defined, it must be broken up into sub issues or sub problems, by asking the questions "what", "why", "when", "where" and "who".

For example, suppose the purpose of a study is to survey clerical salaries in public sector banks in Bangalore city, in order to determine whether salaries in your bank are competitive and consistent. The problem may be broken up as follows:

1. What? – A study of clerical salaries
2. Why? – To determine whether salaries in our firm are competitive and consistent
3. When? – Current
4. Where? – Bangalore city
5. Who? – Clerical employees in public sector banks

Asking the above questions determines the exact scope of the study and reduces the problem to a workable size.

The next step in planning the report is to do an "audience analysis". We have seen that reports may be addressed to internal or external audiences of an organisation. Some of the questions to be asked about the audience or the reader while doing the analysis are:

- Is the audience internal or external to the organisation?
- Who is the specific audience or reader? For example, top management, customers or the government? Reports written for the government and for top management must be more formal than for other audiences.
- Is the audience known to you?
- What is the knowledge level of the audience? Is the topic familiar to the reader? If the report is of a technical nature and the reader is a layperson, the technical terms may need detailed explanation.
- What is the level of interest of the reader? If the report has been solicited or authorised, the reader's level of interest will be high. On the other hand, if the report is voluntary or unsolicited, it may have to sustain the reader's interest.
- What purpose may this report serve the audience?

Usually, audiences can be classified into three types. Figure 3 depicts the three types of audiences.

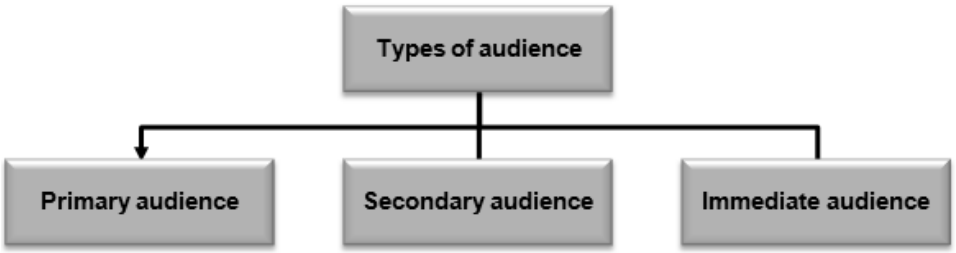


Fig. 3: Types of Audiences

Let us discuss them in brief.

- **Primary audiences** – They are readers to whom your report is specifically directed to. For example, an annual sales report is prepared for top management.
- **Secondary audience** – They are readers beyond the primary audience, but who may also read your report. For example, the annual sales report that you prepared for top management may also be read by Project Managers of other departments of the organisation.
- **Immediate audience** – They are the readers to whom you submit your document. These people are the first to read your document. For example, the annual sales report that you prepare for top management has to be approved by your sales managers. Therefore, your sales managers will be your immediate audience.

The tone, length, complexity and degree of formality of the report will depend largely on the reader's characteristics. For example, reports addressed to peers would adopt a more conversational tone, while reports on company policies and procedures addressed to subordinates would adopt an emphatic tone.

2. **Selecting a method** – After defining the problem and doing the audience analysis, a method has to be selected to collect or gather the necessary information to solve the problem. Broadly, information may be gathered using secondary research methods such as books, magazines, newspapers, internet and other available sources or through primary research methods like surveys that provide firsthand information.

3. **Gathering and organising data** – Once the method of gathering information has been selected, the actual process of gathering the information begins. As this is time-consuming and expensive, only information that is relevant to the report and the study must be gathered. The raw data must be evaluated for its usefulness and organised in a form that is easy and meaningful to understand. Tables, charts, graphs and summaries must be used to do this.

4. **Arriving at a conclusion** – Once the information has been checked for its validity and reliability, it must be interpreted and conclusions must be drawn. Correct interpretation of the data is needed for the success of the report. Sound conclusions cannot be made if the interpretation of the data is faulty. The common mistake made in the interpretation of data is the tendency of the researcher to use subjective judgments, instead of objective reasoning based on facts.

5. **Writing the report** – The actual process of writing the report must begin only after a satisfactory solution to the problem is found. You have to remember that a well written report that contains a bad answer is worse than a badly written report that contains a good answer.

   Once you are ready to begin writing, certain procedures for writing must be followed, they are:

   - **Set a date for completion of the report and get started early** – Begin by first preparing an outline and writing an initial draft, which can be refined later. As starting late is bound to affect the quality of the report.
   - **Start with an easy section** – It is best to start writing those sections of the report which you feel are easier than others. This will help you to get into the rhythm of writing, which will be carried over to the more difficult sections.
   - **Write quickly, with the intention of rewriting** – It is better to put down your thoughts on paper in the form of a rough draft and to get this done quickly. Once this difficult part is over, it becomes easier to improve.
   - **Set aside uninterrupted writing time** – A long block of uninterrupted writing time, such as three to four hours a day, must be set aside for writing the report. Interruptions can make you lose your chain of thought.
   - **Review and rewrite where necessary** – Ideally, the report must be reviewed a couple of times, to see if any improvement is needed. The first review must be to see if any improvement in content is needed, while the second review must check for any errors in writing style, grammar, spelling and punctuation.

   Reports must also be written in a convincing manner, so that the reader accepts them as valid and reliable. Some suggested techniques to achieve them are:

   - **State the facts in an objective manner** – Avoid using superlatives and emotional terms that introduce bias in the research or that suggest that you are passing judgment. For example, avoid saying “There was an ‘incredible’ increase in sales, compared to last year.” Instead,

simply state the amount or percentage of increase. This will be more acceptable to the reader. For example, "There was an increase in sales from 23% in last year to 56% this year."

- **Provide expert opinions** – Although facts are more convincing than the opinions of others, they may not always be available. In this case, the opinions of a specialist in the field may be presented, highlighting the background and experience of the expert. This can enhance the credibility of the report.

  For example, "This is the opinion of an eminent lawyer, who has over three decades of experience in dealing with similar cases."

- **Use documentation** – Footnotes are one way of mentioning the sources of the information presented in the report. A bibliography or list of references is another way of providing documentation. This helps to convince the reader that the information is based on reliable sources.

  Business reports must be carefully worded, adopting certain techniques of writing style you can write an effective report and they are:

- **Use 'concrete' nouns** – Business reports must use concrete nouns, rather than abstract nouns as the subject of sentences, as they are easier to visualise.

  For example, "Mr. Johnson authorised the study."

  Here, Mr. Johnson is a concrete noun and is easy to visualize.

  Compare this with the sentence "Authorisation for the study was received by Mr. Johnson". Here an abstract noun, "authorisation", is the subject of the sentence and is harder to visualise.

- **Avoid pronouns referring to the writer or reader** – The first-person pronoun "I" and the second person pronoun "you" must be avoided in business reports, as far as possible. The use of "I" risks placing more emphasis on the writer of the report, rather than on the ideas.

  For example, "I conducted face-to-face interviews with fifty respondents." This draws more attention to the writer and must be avoided. It is better to emphasise the idea by writing the same as, "Face-to-face interviews were conducted among fifty respondents".

- **Use tenses correctly** – If you are writing a research report and reporting or summarising some of the findings, the past tense is preferable.

  For example, "Almost 80% of the respondents were not aware of the new product."

  "Of the remaining 20%, five respondents were satisfied with the product's features."

  However, once the findings have been presented and you are drawing conclusions, the present tense must be used.

  For example, "Almost 80% of the respondents are not aware of the new product."

"Of the remaining 20%, five respondents are satisfied with the product's features."

- **Use 'transition' sentences** – The report must be written so as to flow a logical sequence. A transition sentence summarises one section of the report and leads the reader smoothly into the next section.

  For example, "While the costs of this new initiative are more than what were anticipated, the benefits outweigh the costs, as listed below."

  This sentence leads the reader from a discussion on costs to a section on benefits, as a result of a cost-benefit analysis.
- **Define key terms carefully** – Important terms and words must be defined properly, explaining what the word means, rather than what the word is about.

  For example, "A dictionary is a book containing an alphabetical list of all words in a particular language" is a more complete definition. Instead, we can define it as "A dictionary has to do with words in a language."

Reports must be free from grammatical and spelling errors as they might lead to confusion. Therefore, it is very important to thoroughly review the report after writing it.

Dos and don'ts

Some of the dos and don'ts of business report writing are,

- ***Use concise and direct writing* –** When it comes to preparing a business report, don't beat around the bush. Don't use unnecessary, excess language and keeping your documents concise and direct.
- ***Use standard language when possible* –** When you are preparing abusiness report, you should use standard and even basic language whenever possible.
- ***Don't over write* –** When it comes to business report writing, don't repeat points that have already been mentioned. Don't mention any unnecessary and irrelevant points in the report.
- ***Prepare an outline* –** Before actually beginning the task of writing a business report, prepare a thorough and comprehensive outline. By developing an overall and comprehensive outline, you will be better able to make certain that you include all of the items that need to be addressed in a particular business report.
- ***Take the time to revise* –** By taking the time to revise and re-draft, you will be able to eliminate many of the business report writing problems that commonly can occur and that have been discussed previously in this article.

Additional Reference:

Bowden, J. (2004). Writing a Report: How to Prepare, Write and Present Effective Reports. UK: How To Books Ltd.

SELF-ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS – 3

True or False:	
10	Reports are written after a problem is analyzed and a solution to the problem is found. (True/False)
Fill in the Blanks:	
11	_____of the data is needed for the success of the report.
12	A _____sentence summarizes one section of the report and leads the reader smoothly into the next section.
Choose the Correct Answer:	
13	Business reports must use _____nouns. a) Concrete b) Abstract c) Proper d) Common

6. WRITING PERSUASIVE PROPOSALS

A business proposal is a document that explains a product or service a company offers to a potential client. It's like a sales pitch, showing what the business can do and why it's better than competitors. Business proposals are important in sales when buyers look at more than just price to make a decision.

When buyers need more than just price details to make a decision, they often refer to a business proposal. There are two types of business proposals: Solicited business proposals and unsolicited business proposals. A solicited business proposal is written when someone asks a company for a proposal while an unsolicited proposal is sent to potential clients by companies, in order to invite their attention. The latter is harder to write because they require research on the client to understand their needs and show how the company can help.

The main goal of a business proposal is to convince the client to choose the company's products or services. Towards this, the proposal should focus on a problem that needs to be fixed and explain a practical way to fix the problem. The proposal should also include details on why the company is a perfect choice for fixing the problem, the total expenditure for the fixes and other probable advantages.

Creating a persuasive business proposal is essential for building strong client relationships, driving business growth, and achieving success. It helps the business by addressing client needs and providing a solution, detailing on its monetary worth, leading to better decisions and outcomes from the part of the client.

6.1. Key elements of persuasive business proposal

A persuasive business proposal includes an executive summary, problem identification, solution, team's qualifications, pricing, call to action, and conclusion. Each part helps address the client's needs and shows the value of the solution provided.

1. Executive summary- This is the first impression the client will have of the proposal. To write a strong executive summary, give a brief overview of the proposal, highlighting the problem, solution, and benefits. Keep it clear, engaging, and honest to encourage the client to keep going. Avoid overpromising and aim to connect with the client.
2. Problem identification: When explaining the problem, make sure it's clear and directly relevant to the client's business. Use the language of the client to show that the company understands their challenges. Focus on their needs, not just the company's perspective. Avoid

defining the problem solely from the perspective of the company, as the proposal should focus on what the client needs to solve. If the client fails to see the problem, they will not see the need for a solution too.

3. Qualifications: The team's qualifications can be highlighted by providing evidence of past successes as well as by including testimonials and reviews from previous clients. The claims should be transparent and verifiable, and any overstatement about the team's capabilities can create doubt in the minds of the clients, thereby harming the reputation of the company.
4. Pricing: Be transparent about the pricing in the proposal. Offer a clear understanding of the value the client would receive in return for their investment. Provide different pricing options and packages to fit their budget and needs. Avoid any hidden cost, which will increase trust towards the company in the mind of the client.
5. Call to Action: Create a clear call to action by summarising your proposal, outlining next steps, and making it easy for the client to contact the company. Use active language to encourage prompt action but avoid being too pushy. Respect the client's timeline and decision-making process.
6. Conclusion: This part leaves a lasting impression on the client. The main points can be summarised here and the benefits of the solution reiterated before thanking the client for their time and leaving them for a clear action to be taken ahead.

6.2. Common mistakes to avoid in business proposals

Avoid common mistakes in business proposals, such as overpromising, focusing only on the company perspective, overcomplicating solutions, making unsupported claims, hiding costs, being too pushy, or adding new details in the conclusion. Steering clear of these errors makes the proposal more effective and persuasive.

7. SUMMARY

Let us recapitulate the important concepts discussed in this unit:

- A business report is defined as an orderly and objective presentation of information that helps in decision-making and problem-solving.
- A report varies in purpose, length, format and complexity and also the quality of a report is affected by the quality and accuracy of the data.
- The four types of reports are:
  - Periodic reports
  - Proposals
  - Policies and procedures
  - Situational reports
- Depending on the length of the report the format of a business report varies. Usually, a report follows a memo format.
- A business report generally consists of the following items:
  - Preliminary parts
  - Body of the report
  - Addenda or annexes
- In order to create an effective report, you can follow the following steps:
  - Planning the report
  - Selecting a method
  - Gathering and organizing data
  - Arriving at a conclusion
  - Writing the report
- A business proposal is a document that explains a product or service a company offers to a potential client.
- A persuasive business proposal includes an executive summary, problem identification, solution, team's qualifications, pricing, call to action, and conclusion.

8. GLOSSARY

Concrete noun	-	A noun (such as chicken or egg) that names a material or tangible object or phenomenon-something recognizable through the senses.
Layperson	-	A person without professional or specialized knowledge in a particular subject.
Solicited	-	To seek to obtain by persuasion, entreaty, or formal application.
Superlatives	-	The highest degree of comparison.

9. TERMINAL QUESTIONS

1. Write a note on the characteristics of a business report.
2. List the type of business reports. Explain.
3. Write a note on report format.
4. List the steps for preparing a report. Explain.
5. Explain the techniques that you can follow to write a report in a convincing manner, so that the reader accepts them as valid and reliable.

10. ANSWERS

10.1. Self-Assessment Questions

1. True
2. Data collected
3. Policies and procedures
4. Compliance reports
5. False. As the size of the report increases, a number of extra parts can be added, in order to assist the reader in understanding the report.
6. True
7. b) Recommendations
8. Introduction
9. Technical, layperson
10. True
11. Correct interpretation
12. Transition
13. Concrete
14. Transition

10.2. Terminal Questions Answers

1. A report varies in purpose, length, format and complexity. Also, the quality of a report is affected by the quality and accuracy of the data. For more details, refer to section 2.
2. Business reports can be classified as periodic reports, policies and procedures, proposals and situational reports. For more details, refer to section 3.
3. Report format varies with the length of the report. As the length increases the assistance items that are included in the report also increase. These assisting items make it easy for the reader to understand and read the report easily. For more details, refer to section 4.
4. The steps for preparing a report comprises planning the report, selecting a method, gathering and organizing data, arriving at a conclusion and writing the report. For more details, refer to section 5.
5. In order to write a convincing report, you have to state the facts in an objective manner, provide expert opinions, and use documentation. For more details, refer to section 5.

11. CASE STUDY

Research Report

The following research report was prepared in UniLab on staff attitude.

Executive Summary

The aim of this report was to investigate UniLab staff attitudes to personal mobile phone use in staff and team meetings. A staff survey on

attitudes towards the use of mobile phones in staff / team meetings was conducted. The results indicate that the majority of staff found that the use of mobile phones is a major issue in staff meetings. The report concludes that personal mobile phones are disruptive and should be turned off in meetings. It is recommended that UniLab develops a company policy banning the use of mobile phones except in exceptional circumstances.

Introduction

There has been a massive increase in the use of personal mobile phones over the past five years and there is every indication that this will continue. According to Black (2002) by 2008 almost 100% of working people in Australia will carry personal mobile phones. Black describes this phenomenon as 'serious in the extreme, potentially undermining the foundations of communication in our society' (2002, p 167). Currently at UniLab 89% of staff have a personal mobile phone.

Recently a few of the staff have complained about the use of personal mobile phones in meetings and asked what the official company policy is. At present there is no official company policy regarding phone use. This report examines the issue of mobile phone usage in staff meetings and small team meetings. It does not seek to examine the use of mobile phones in the workplace at other times, although some concerns were raised.

For the purpose of this report a personal mobile phone is a personally funded phone for private calls as opposed to an employer funded phone that directly relates to carrying out a particular job.

Methods

This research was conducted by questionnaire and investigated UniLab staff members' attitudes to the use of mobile phones in staff / team meetings. A total of 412 questionnaires were distributed with employees' fortnightly pay slips (see Appendix 1). The questionnaire used Lekert scales to assess social attitudes (see Smith 2002) to mobile phone usage and provided open-ended responses

for additional comments. Survey collection boxes were located in every branch for a four-week period. No personal information was collected; the survey was voluntary and anonymous.

Results

There was an 85% response rate to the questionnaire. A breakdown of the responses is listed in Table 13.5. It can be clearly seen from the results that mobile phones are considered to be disruptive and should be turned off in meetings.

Table 13.5: Breakdown of the Responses

Personal mobile phone usage in staff and team meetings are…	Strongly agree %	Agree %	Disagree %	Strongly disagree %
Not a problem	5	7	65	23
An issue	40	45	10	5
Disruptive	80	10	7	3
Phones should be permissible	6	16	56	22
Phones should be turned off	85	10	3	2
Allowed in some circumstances	10	52	24	14

The survey also allowed participants to identify any circumstances where mobile phones should be allowed in meetings and also assessed staff attitudes towards receiving personal phone calls in staff meetings in open-ended questions. These results showed that staff thought that in some circumstances, for example, medical emergencies, receiving personal phone calls was acceptable, but generally receiving personal phone calls was not necessary.

Discussion / Interpretation of Results

It can be seen from the results in Table 13.5 that personal mobile phone use is considered to be a problem; however, it was acknowledged that in some situations it should be permissible. 80% of recipients considered mobile phones to be highly disruptive and there was strong support for phones being turned off in meetings (85%). Only 12% thought that mobile phone usage in staff and team meetings was not a problem, whereas 85% felt it was an issue. The results are consistent throughout the survey. Many of the respondents (62%) felt that in exceptional circumstances mobile phones should be allowed, for example, medical, but there should be protocols regarding this.

These findings are consistent with other studies. According to Smith (2005) many companies have identified mobile phones as disruptive and have banned the use of mobile phones in meetings. Havir (2004) claims that 29% of staff meeting time is wasted through unnecessary mobile phone interruptions. This affects time management, productivity and team focus.

Conclusion

The use of mobile phones in staff meetings is clearly disruptive and they should be switched off. Most staff felt it is not necessary to receive personal phone calls in staff meetings except under certain circumstances, but permission should first be sought from the team leader, manager or chair.

Recommendations

It is recommended that UniLab develops an official policy regarding the use of mobile phones in staff meetings. The policy should be recommended:

- mobile phones are banned in staff meetings.
- mobile phones may be used in exceptional circumstances but only with the permission of the appropriate manager or chair.

Finally, the policy needs to apply to all staff in the company.

(Source: https://www.dlsweb.rmit.edu.au/lsu/content/2_assessmenttasks/assess_tuts/reports_ll/report.pdf)

Discussion Questions:

1. What is the report about?

   (Hint: Refer 'Executive Summary' in the Case Study)

2. Is the report structured well? Explain.

   (Hint: Refer section 4)

12. REFERENCES

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- Ober, S. (2004). Contemporary Business Communication, 5th ed. New Delhi: Dreamtech Press.
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